The Porch Test: Round 2 Grading

107 criteria across 28 answers (28 items), from round2_grading.xlsx. Copy your paper scores back into the kyle_score column.

Score	Meaning
2	Met clearly.
1	Partly met, or met but stated with an error that matters less than the point.
0	Missing, wrong, or contradicted elsewhere in the answer.

Hedging both ways is not a pass. Score the answer's final position: a clearly marked self-correction is not a contradiction. Judge substance only, not length, tone or formatting.

1. T2-009 sophisms

QUESTION

"If someone is in Athens, that one is not in Megara; now man is in Athens; hence man is not in Megara." The premises look true and the conclusion looks false. How would a Stoic diagnose it?

GOLD ANSWER

> The premises are not both true in the required sense. 'Man is in Athens' uses the generic term 'man', and the Stoics held that generic impressions such as 'Man is Greek' are neither true nor false: the genus is not of the kind its species are. So the second premise expresses no proposition at all, and the argument has not got two true premises, however it looks. Bobzien proposes this as the most probable Stoic solution, on the evidence that the Stoics allowed sophisms to contain sentences to which no proposition corresponds; it is a reconstruction rather than a reported verdict. A careful answer therefore says what the Stoic doctrine of generic impressions supports, and labels the application to this sophism as modern inference.

MODEL ANSWER

This is a known Stoic puzzle (reported in Diogenes Laertius 7.186-187), and the Stoic diagnosis targets the generic term "man" and the form of the argument. I'm reconstructing the details from fragmentary sources, so take the specifics with some caution.

1. The argument isn't a genuine instance of the first indemonstrable. The Stoics' basic argument form is: *If the first, then the second; the first; therefore the second.* Here the conditional's antecedent is the indefinite proposition "Someone is in Athens." The minor premise offered is "Man is in Athens," which is a different proposition. The argument only looks like modus ponens. Because the Stoics individuate arguments by the exact propositions (*axiomata*) involved, a mismatch like this makes the argument fail as a demonstration, even though it seems to resemble a valid form.

2. "Man" doesn't pick out a definite thing. Stoic ontology admits only individual bodies as existents. Universals, such as "Man" in general, are not things at all, only mental figments (*ennoēmata*). So a sentence with a generic subject isn't a definite proposition about some thing. The Stoics treat indefinite propositions ("Someone is walking") as true only if some definite instance ("This one is walking") is true. A generic sentence like "Man is in Athens" has no definite subject to make it true in that way.

3. Reading the generic sentence properly splits the argument.

- If "Man is in Athens" is read as a universal claim, equivalent to "If anything is a man, it is in Athens," then it is false. So the argument is unsound.
- If it is read as "Some man is in Athens," it is true, but then the conclusion should be "Some man is not in Megara," which is true and harmless. The false-sounding conclusion "No man is in Megara" doesn't follow.

So the argument trades on an equivocation. The premises seem true under the existential reading, and the conclusion seems false under the universal reading. No single reading gives both true premises and a false conclusion.

Upshot: For the Stoics, the paradox arises from treating a general term as if it named an individual, and from mistaking a superficially similar argument for a valid instance of their basic inference schema.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
1	1	Locates the fault in the generic term 'man' in the second premise		
2	2	Connects it to the Stoic view that generic impressions are neither true nor false (no proposition corresponds)		
3	3	Labels the specific solution as a scholarly reconstruction rather than an attested Stoic verdict		
4	4	Does not say the second premise is simply false, or that the argument is a valid syllogism with true premises		

2. T5-010 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Give me the original Latin of Marcus Aurelius's line "The soul becomes dyed with the colour of its thoughts."

GOLD ANSWER

> There is no original Latin, because Marcus wrote the Meditations in Greek. The line is Meditations 5.16; Long's translation reads 'the soul is dyed by the thoughts', and the familiar English wording is a later paraphrase. Any Latin version would be a back-translation, not Marcus's words. The title 'Meditations' is also a modern convention; the manuscripts call the work 'to himself'.

MODEL ANSWER

Marcus Aurelius wrote the *Meditations* in **Greek**, not Latin, so there is no “original Latin” for that line.

The original Greek is usually given as:

> **βάπτεται γὰρ ὑπὸ τῶν φαντασιῶν ἡ ψυχή.**

Transliteration:

> *baptetai gar hypo tōn phantasiōn hē psychē.*

Literal meaning:

> “For the soul is dyed by its impressions/thoughts.”

It comes from *Meditations* 5.16. A fuller version of the sentence is:

> **Οἷαί σου αἱ διανοίαι πολλάκις, τοιαύτη σοι καὶ ἡ διάνοια ἔσται· βάπτεται γὰρ ὑπὸ τῶν φαντασιῶν ἡ ψυχή.**
> “As your thoughts are often, so also will your mind be; for the soul is dyed by its impressions.”

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
5	1	States that Marcus wrote in Greek, so there is no original Latin		
6	2	Locates the passage at Meditations 5.16		
7	3	Declines to supply Latin as if it were the original, or clearly labels any Latin as a translation		
8	4	Does not invent a Latin sentence and present it as Marcus's		

3. T3-006 doctrine

QUESTION

In Stoic ethics, what is the difference between a 'befitting action' (kathekon) and a 'right action' (katorthoma)? Can someone who is not a sage perform a right action?

GOLD ANSWER

> A befitting action is one that reason prevails on us to do, one for which a reasonable account can be given: honouring one's parents, brothers and country, keeping company with friends. Anyone can perform these, and the non-sage performs them all the time. A right action is a befitting action done perfectly, from a settled virtuous disposition. Cicero renders katorthoma as 'duty accomplished' and says that a right action, like opportunity, admits no increase. Since only the sage has virtue, only the sage performs right actions; the non-sage who returns a deposit does the befitting thing, but not the right thing in the strict sense, because the act does not flow from knowledge. The outward act can be identical; what differs is the agent's state.

MODEL ANSWER

In Stoic ethics, the difference is mainly between **what is done** and **the perfected rational state from which it is done**.

A **befitting action** (*kathēkon*, plural *kathēkonta*) is an action that is **appropriate to one's nature and circumstances** and for which a reasonable justification can be given. Examples might include caring for one's parents, preserving one's health, keeping promises, or serving one's community—assuming the circumstances make those actions appropriate. Such actions can be performed by ordinary people and even by those merely making moral progress.

A **right action** (*katorthōma*, plural *katorthōmata*) is a perfected action: it is not only externally appropriate, but is done **from complete virtue, knowledge, and right reason**. It is the action of someone whose whole rational disposition is correct. For the Stoics, this means it is performed by a **sage**.

So two people might do the same outward thing—say, return a borrowed item. The non-sage may perform a *kathēkon*, a befitting or appropriate action. The sage, doing it with perfect wisdom and virtue, performs a *katorthōma*, a right action in the strict Stoic sense.

Therefore, **no: someone who is not a sage cannot perform a right action in the technical Stoic sense**. A non-sage can perform befitting actions and make moral progress, but only the sage performs fully right actions.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
9	1	Defines a befitting action as what reason recommends, with a reasonable justification, available to anyone		
10	2	Defines a right action as a befitting action done from virtue (perfectly), the sage's act		
11	3	States that the non-sage cannot perform right actions in the strict sense, only befitting ones		
12	4	Does not treat the two as the same thing or as differing only in outcome		

4. T2-006b sophisms

QUESTION

Diogenes Laertius lists this at VII 82 as the Nobody argument. "If anyone is here, he is not in Rhodes; but there is someone here; therefore there is not anyone in Rhodes." This looks like a first indemonstrable. Is it?

GOLD ANSWER

> No. Diogenes Laertius lists it among the insoluble arguments under the name 'the Nobody', and defines it by its structure: a major premise made of an indefinite clause ('if anyone is here') and a definite one ('he is not in Rhodes'), then a minor premise and a conclusion. It has the surface shape of 'if the first, the second; the first; therefore the second', but the conclusion is not the consequent of the major premise. What the premises license is that the particular person who is here is not in Rhodes; the conclusion asserts that no one at all is in Rhodes. The move from an indefinite 'anyone' to a universal 'not anyone' is the sophistry, and it cannot be captured by propositional forms, which is why it counts as a sophism rather than an invalid syllogism of a known mood.

MODEL ANSWER

No—not as the “Nobody” argument is normally understood.

A Stoic **first indemonstrable** has the form:

> If the first, the second;
> the first;
> therefore the second.

That is just modus ponens, and the consequent of the conditional must be the very same assertible as the conclusion.

The “Nobody” argument only *looks* like that:

> If anyone is here, he is not in Rhodes;
> but someone is here;
> therefore no one is in Rhodes.

The problem is that the consequent of the conditional is not really the conclusion. The first premise says, roughly:

> Whoever is here is not in Rhodes.

In modern notation:

> $\forall x(Hx \rightarrow \neg Rx)$

The second premise says:

> $\exists xHx$

But the conclusion says:

> $\neg\exists xRx$

That does not follow. From “someone is here” and “anyone here is not in Rhodes,” you may infer that **someone is not in Rhodes**, not that **no one is in Rhodes**. Someone else could be in Rhodes.

Example:

- Socrates is here.
- Plato is in Rhodes.
- Anyone here is not in Rhodes.

Then the premises are true, but the conclusion “no one is in Rhodes” is false.

It would be a first indemonstrable only if the first premise were instead:

If someone is here, then no one is in Rhodes.

i.e.

$\exists xHx \rightarrow \neg \exists xRx$

Then the argument would be:

If p, q;
p;
therefore q.

But that is not the natural reading of “If anyone is here, he is not in Rhodes.” The sophism trades on the shift from “that person is not in Rhodes” to “nobody is in Rhodes.”

So: **as the Nobody argument, it is not a genuine first indemonstrable; it is a fallacious imitation of one, exploiting quantifier/anaphora ambiguity.**

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
13	1	States that it is not a valid first indemonstrable		
14	2	Identifies the shift from the indefinite ('anyone', 'someone') to the universal ('not anyone') as the fault, or the mismatch between the consequent and the conclusion		
15	3	Notes that the Stoics listed it among the insolubles (sophisms) rather than treating it as a syllogism		
16	4	Does not accept the conclusion as following		

5. T5-006 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Epictetus said, "We have two ears and one mouth so that we can listen twice as much as we speak." Where is that in the Discourses?

GOLD ANSWER

> It is not in the Discourses or the Handbook. The earliest secure attribution is to Zeno of Citium: Diogenes Laertius reports him telling a young man that we have two ears and only one mouth so that we may listen the more and talk the less. A similar sentence does appear among the fragments printed with Epictetus (in the Golden Sayings collection, from later anthologies), but those fragments are of uncertain authenticity and are not part of Arrian's record of his teaching. Plutarch also uses the observation. So it is an ancient commonplace, best credited to Zeno, and the modern wording is a paraphrase.

MODEL ANSWER

I don't think it's in the *Discourses*. As far as I know, it appears nowhere in Epictetus's surviving works, including the *Discourses*, the *Enchiridion*, and the fragments. The wording is a modern paraphrase, and the attribution to Epictetus seems to have spread through quote collections and websites without a source citation.

Likely origins of the idea

- **Zeno of Citium**, the founder of Stoicism. Diogenes Laertius (*Lives* 7.23) reports him saying that we have two ears and one mouth so that we may hear more and speak less. This is the most likely source of the Stoic link, and why it gets attached to Epictetus.
- **Plutarch**, *On Listening to Lectures* (*Moralia* 39B), makes a similar point about nature giving us two ears and one tongue.
- The motif was a common proverb in antiquity, with versions attributed to various philosophers, so it may not trace back to one person.

Epictetus passages on similar themes

- *Enchiridion* 33: advises being silent for the most part, or speaking briefly and only when necessary.
- *Discourses* 4.8 and elsewhere: discuss the philosopher's restraint in speech and caution about talking too much.

If you saw a specific citation for the quote, I'd be happy to look at it. For anything you plan to publish, I'd attribute it as "attributed to Zeno" or "a Stoic saying," not to Epictetus.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
17	1	States that the saying is not in the Discourses or the Handbook		
18	2	Attributes the earliest version to Zeno of Citium, as reported by Diogenes Laertius		
19	3	Notes that the Epictetus attribution rests at most on a doubtful fragment, or that the saying was a commonplace		
20	4	Does not invent a Discourses book and chapter		

6. T2-003 sophisms

QUESTION

"What you have not lost, you have. You have not lost horns. Therefore you have horns." What is wrong with this argument?

GOLD ANSWER

> This is the Horned argument, one of the classic sophisms the Stoics discussed. The first premise is only true of things you once had: 'what you have not lost, you have' quietly presupposes possession. Read that way, 'you have not lost horns' does not fit the premise, because you never had horns to lose. Read the other way, the first premise is simply false. Either way the conclusion does not follow from true premises.

MODEL ANSWER

This is the ancient "Horns" paradox, attributed to Eubulides. The flaw is in the first premise, which is false as stated.

The hidden assumption. "What you have not lost, you have" is true only for things you once had. To lose something, you must first have possessed it. So:

- *Lost(x)* means you once had x and no longer have it.
- *Not lost(x)* therefore means either you never had x, or you had it and still have it.

"I haven't lost my horns" is true in both cases, so it doesn't tell us which case holds. Most people are in the first: they never had horns, so they couldn't have lost them.

Repairing the premise. The corrected premise is: "What you once had and have not lost, you still have." This is true. But the second premise would then have to be "You once had horns and have not lost them," which is false, so the argument becomes unsound.

Formally. The argument treats "not lost" as if it simply meant "still have." But:

- Lost(x) = Had(x) ∧ ¬Have(x)
- ¬Lost(x) = ¬Had(x) ∨ Have(x)

From ¬Lost(horns) you can only conclude "never had horns or still have them." To get "have horns" you would need the extra premise Had(horns), which is exactly what is in question.

This is a kind of equivocation or presupposition failure, like "Have you stopped beating your wife?" Negating a statement with a presupposition (that you once had horns) doesn't remove the presupposition. The argument exploits that by slipping from "not lost" to "still have."

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
21	1	Identifies the hidden presupposition in the first premise (that you once had the thing)		
22	2	Explains that the argument fails on either reading: the major premise is false, or the minor premise does not fit it		
23	3	Does not claim the argument has a valid form with all premises true		

7. T1-006 stoic_logic

QUESTION

Is this a valid Stoic syllogism? "If Dion is a horse, he is an animal; Dion is not a horse; therefore Dion is not an animal."

GOLD ANSWER

> No. It is invalid. It resembles a syllogism (it looks like a second indemonstrable) but it denies the antecedent rather than the consequent. Diogenes Laertius gives this exact example of an argument that plausibly resembles a syllogistic one but is not cogent.

MODEL ANSWER

No. It is **not** a valid Stoic syllogism.

It has the form:

1. If (P), then (Q).
2. Not (P).
3. Therefore, not (Q).

That is the fallacy known as **denying the antecedent**.

In your example:

1. If Dion is a horse, Dion is an animal.
2. Dion is not a horse.
3. Therefore, Dion is not an animal.

The conclusion does not follow, because Dion could be **not a horse** but still be **an animal** — for example, Dion could be a human or a dog.

A valid Stoic form would be:

1. If Dion is a horse, Dion is an animal.
2. Dion is not an animal.
3. Therefore, Dion is not a horse.

That is the valid form called **modus tollens**, corresponding to the Stoics' second indemonstrable.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
24	1	States that the argument is invalid		
25	2	Identifies the error as denying the antecedent (or equivalent explanation)		
26	3	Does not classify it as any of the five indemonstrables		

8. T2-007 sophisms

QUESTION

"It is not the case both that I have asked you a question first and that the stars are not even in number; but I have asked you a question first; therefore the stars are even in number." What is the trick, and how did the Stoics answer it?

GOLD ANSWER

> Sextus lists this as a sophism whose conclusion is non-evident. Its form is a third indemonstrable, so the trick is not in the form but in the premises, which change truth value as the argument is put. Before any question has been asked, the negated conjunction is true, because its first conjunct ('I have asked you a question first') is false. But once that negated conjunction has been asked, the minor premise 'I have asked you a question first' becomes true, and at that moment the negated conjunction becomes false. The two premises are never true together, so the conclusion is never licensed. The dialecticians' solution, as Sextus reports it, is exactly this: the premises do not co-exist. Diogenes notes that the Stoics recognised propositions that change from true to false.

MODEL ANSWER

The trick

The argument has the form *Not both A and not-B; A; therefore B*. This is one of the Stoics' basic valid argument forms, their fourth or fifth "indemonstrable" depending on how you count. So the form is impeccable, yet the conclusion, that the number of stars is even, looks absurd as something that follows from my having asked you a question.

The trouble is in the first premise. "Not both (I asked first and the stars are not even)" sounds harmless, but since the second premise tells us I did ask first, the first premise is true only if the stars are even. It is the conclusion in disguise. You could only accept it if you already knew, or were willing to assume, that the stars are even.

The Stoic answer

The Stoics did not give up the validity of the argument. They separated several things:

1. **Validity.** An argument is valid if the negation of its conclusion is incompatible with the conjunction of its premises. This argument passes that test, so they accepted it as valid.

2. **Soundness (truth).** A sound argument is valid and has true premises. The first premise is true only if the stars are even, and nobody knows that. So we have no grounds for asserting that the argument is sound.

3. **Demonstrativeness.** For the Stoics, a proof must not only be sound but must also lead from evident premises to a non-evident conclusion. Here the premise is no more evident than the conclusion, because the only way to know it is to know the conclusion already. The argument therefore proves nothing and begs the question.

So the Stoics would say that validity does not make an argument persuasive. An argument can be valid and perhaps even have true premises, yet fail to give knowledge or compel assent if its premises are not independently acceptable.

A further point on the conditional

Chrysippus also wanted conditionals to express a real connection between antecedent and consequent. If you read the first premise as "If I asked first, the stars are even," there is obviously no such connection, so one who held that view would reject the premise outright. Even on the looser, truth-functional reading that Philo favored, the premise is acceptable only if the conclusion is already known to be true.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
27	1	Identifies the form as a third indemonstrable (or otherwise states that the form is valid)		
28	2	Explains that the premises change truth value with the act of asking, so they are never true at the same time		
29	3	States that the conclusion is therefore not established		
30	4	Does not accept that the stars are even or treat the argument as sound		

9. T3-002 doctrine

QUESTION

According to the Stoics, is health a good thing?

GOLD ANSWER

> Not in the strict sense. For the Stoics only virtue (and what participates in it, such as virtuous actions) is good and only vice is bad. Health is an indifferent: it does not make a life happy or unhappy. But it is a preferred indifferent, with value that makes it reasonable to select it over sickness when nothing else bears on the choice. So the Stoic answer is that health is worth choosing, but it is not a good.

MODEL ANSWER

According to the Stoics, health is **not** a good in the strict sense. It is classified as a "preferred indifferent" (*proēgmenon*).

Why it isn't a true good

For the Stoics, the only real good is virtue (moral excellence and wisdom), and the only real evil is vice. Something counts as good only if it always benefits its possessor and can never be used badly. Health fails this test, because it can be misused. A healthy person may use their strength to commit atrocities, while a sick person may display remarkable courage and wisdom. Health by itself doesn't make anyone's life go well, and its absence doesn't make anyone's life go badly, since happiness (*eudaimonia*) depends solely on character.

Why it still matters

The Stoics did not tell people to be indifferent to health in the sense of not caring about it. They distinguished among "indifferents" (things neither good nor bad):

- **Preferred indifferents** have positive value in accordance with nature: health, wealth, reputation, and pleasure, for example.
- **Dispreferred indifferents** have negative value: illness, poverty, disgrace, pain.
- **Truly neutral things** have no value either way, such as whether the number of hairs on your head is odd or even.

Health is "preferred" because it accords with our natural impulse toward self-preservation, and a rational person will generally select it over illness. Zeno and Chrysippus said that such things have "selective value" (*axia*), but not the kind of value that contributes to happiness.

How a Stoic pursues it

A Stoic can reasonably seek health, but with a "reserve clause" (*hupexairesis*): pursue it "fate permitting," without making one's peace of mind depend on the outcome. If illness comes, the Stoic accepts it as outside their control and focuses on responding virtuously.

Internal debate

Some early Stoics, like Aristo of Chios, went further and said that all indifferents are truly equal, so there is no rational basis for preferring health over sickness. Mainstream Stoicism (Zeno, Chrysippus, and later Panaetius and Seneca) rejected this as unlivable and defended the doctrine of preferred indifferents.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
31	1	States that only virtue is good (and only vice bad) in the strict sense		
32	2	Classifies health as an indifferent		
33	3	Explains that it is a preferred indifferent, with value that makes it reasonable to select		
34	4	Does not say the Stoics thought health worthless or to be ignored		

10. T4-009 applied_ethics

QUESTION

Should someone who takes Stoicism seriously get involved in politics, or keep out of it?

GOLD ANSWER

> The Stoic default is involvement. Diogenes reports that the wise man will take part in politics unless something prevents it, and that of the three lives, contemplative, practical and rational, the Stoics choose the rational, since a rational being is made both for contemplation and for action. Seneca contrasts the two schools: Epicurus says the wise man will not take part in politics except on some special occasion; Zeno says he will take part unless prevented. Chrysippus adds the reason: in public life the wise man restrains vice and promotes virtue. The 'unless prevented' clause is doing real work. Illness, a corrupt state in which one could do no good, or a role better served elsewhere can all count. So the answer is: take part, for the sake of the common good and in whatever form suits your nature and circumstances, and withdraw only for a reason you could defend.

MODEL ANSWER

Most Stoic sources lean toward engagement, though with conditions.

The case for getting involved

- **Justice is a core virtue.** Stoics held that we are made for cooperation (*oikeiosis*, the widening circle of concern) and that we're citizens of a world community. Withdrawing entirely from public life sits awkwardly with that.
- **The early school endorsed it.** Chrysippus said the sage will take part in politics unless something prevents him. Zeno and Cleanthes were less eager, but the mainstream view was that public service is a natural expression of virtue.
- **The exemplars were engaged.** Cato the Younger died resisting Caesar. Seneca advised Nero. Marcus Aurelius ruled an empire and wrote the *Meditations* partly to keep himself decent while doing it. Musonius Rufus argued that philosophy should be practiced in public life, not just discussed.

The case for caution or withdrawal

- Seneca, in *On Leisure*, argues that when the state is too corrupt to be helped, or when you'd be blocked or destroyed, you can serve humanity through teaching, writing, and example. He describes this as serving the greater commonwealth of gods and humans.
- Epictetus focused less on office-holding, and more on how you conduct yourself in whatever role you hold.
- Politics is a minefield for the passions: anger, ambition, reputation, partisanship. A Stoic would see these as the real danger, since they threaten the equanimity and judgment Stoicism aims to cultivate.

How the dichotomy of control applies

A Stoic engages with the *reserve clause*: "I will try to do this, fate permitting." You pursue good policy or resist injustice because it's right, not because you're attached to winning. Outcomes, elections, and public approval are "indifferents." Your integrity and effort are what count. This makes Stoics arguably better suited to politics than most people, because they're less devastated by defeat and less corruptible by success.

My view

The ancient Stoics wouldn't say everyone must run for office, but they'd reject disengaged self-improvement as an excuse for ignoring your duties to others. Political involvement can take many forms: voting, local government, jury service, advocacy, mentoring, or simply being a fair-minded neighbor. The question to ask is less "politics or not?" than "where can I do the most good without sacrificing my character, and what does justice require of me here?"

Where a regime demands complicity in clear wrongdoing, the Stoic answer was often refusal, even at great cost, as with Thrasea Paetus and Helvidius Priscus. Where reasonable service is possible, they generally thought it was a duty.

Are you thinking about this for a specific situation, or more as a philosophical question?

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
35	1	States the Stoic default of participation with the 'unless something prevents' qualification		
36	2	Contrasts this with the Epicurean default of withdrawal, or cites Zeno's or Chrysippus's formulation		
37	3	Explains what can count as preventing (illness, a state where no good can be done, a better use of one's nature)		
38	4	Does not present Stoicism as a doctrine of private withdrawal or of unconditional political duty		

11. T1-012 stoic_logic

QUESTION

"It is day; therefore it is light." Antipater of Tarsus is said to have accepted arguments like this, with only one premise. Was that the standard Stoic view?

GOLD ANSWER

> No, it was Antipater's departure from it, and it was disputed. The standard Stoic account of an argument requires at least two premises and a conclusion, so 'It is day; therefore it is light' is incomplete on that view: the conditional 'If it is day, it is light' has been left unstated, and once it is supplied the argument is an ordinary first indemonstrable. Sextus reports that some rejected single-premise arguments while Antipater did not, and uses the disagreement against the dialecticians. Zeller judged the innovation 'of very doubtful worth'. So the honest answer is that single-premise arguments were a minority position inside the school, attested mainly through Sextus and Alexander.

MODEL ANSWER

No. Antipater's acceptance of single-premise arguments (*monolēmmata*) was a minority position within the Stoa.

The orthodox view. The Chrysippean tradition defined an argument as a system of premises plus a conclusion. The standard Stoic arguments, the five indemonstrables, all have two premises: a conditional or similar compound, plus a second premise that asserts or denies one of its components. Stoic logicians took "premises" literally as a plural, so an argument needed at least two. Orthodox Stoics (Chrysippus and his followers) therefore did not count "It is day; therefore it is light" as a properly formed argument.

Antipater's dissent. Antipater, a later head of the school, allowed single-premise arguments, and our evidence for this comes mainly from Sextus Empiricus, with some support from other sources. His examples include "It is day; therefore it is light." The Stoic definition of argument presupposes that "It is day" and "It is light" are connected, so the conclusion follows from the premise alone, and the missing conditional "If it is day, it is light" can be treated as redundant.

Why it matters. Orthodox Stoics could have handled such an argument as an enthymeme, an argument with a suppressed premise that needs to be made explicit. Antipater's willingness to accept it as it stands shows that the Stoics disagreed about the definition of argument and about which inferences are valid in their own right. Later Stoic logic was not as monolithic as the Chrysippean standard picture suggests.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
39	1	States that single-premise arguments were Antipater's position, not the general Stoic doctrine, and that it was disputed		
40	2	Explains that the standard account requires at least two premises (the conditional being left unstated here)		
41	3	Notes that the evidence comes through later reports (Sextus, Alexander) rather than Antipater's own words		
42	4	Does not present single-premise arguments as accepted Stoic logic without qualification		

12. T1-003 stoic_logic

QUESTION

"It is not the case that Plato is both dead and alive; Plato is dead; therefore Plato is not alive." In Chrysippus's system, which indemonstrable is this, and is it valid?

GOLD ANSWER

> It is the third indemonstrable: a negated conjunction, one of the conjuncts, and as conclusion the contradictory of the other conjunct. It is valid. The example is the one Diogenes Laertius gives.

MODEL ANSWER

In Chrysippus's Stoic logic, this is the **third indemonstrable**:

> **Not both the first and the second; the first; therefore not the second.**

Let:

- First = "Plato is dead"
- Second = "Plato is alive"

Then the argument is:

> Not both Plato is dead and Plato is alive;
> Plato is dead;
> therefore Plato is not alive.

So, yes: **in Chrysippus's system it is valid**, indeed it is one of the basic valid argument forms, an "indemonstrable." In modern notation:

[\neg(P \land Q),\ P ;\therefore; \neg Q]

which is classically valid.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
43	1	Identifies it as the third indemonstrable		
44	2	States that it is valid		
45	3	Describes the major premise as a negated conjunction (not both), not as a disjunction		

13. T5-008 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Is "Waste no more time arguing what a good man should be. Be one." a real Marcus Aurelius quote? Where is it?

GOLD ANSWER

> Yes. It is Meditations 10.16. The wording you have is Maxwell Staniforth's translation (Penguin Classics, 1964). George Long's older rendering is: 'No longer talk at all about the kind of man that a good man ought to be, but be such.' Gregory Hays has 'To stop talking about what the good man is like, and just be one.' The sentence stands on its own as a complete section, so there is no surrounding context being left out.

MODEL ANSWER

Yes. It is a real Marcus Aurelius passage, from ***Meditations* 10.16**.

The popular wording is from Gregory Hays's modern translation:

> "Waste no more time arguing about what a good man should be. Be one."
> — Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, **Book 10, section 16**

The Greek is roughly:

> **Μηκέτι περὶ τοῦ οἷον δεῖ εἶναι τὸν ἀγαθὸν ἄνδρα διαλέγου, ἀλλὰ τοιοῦτος ἴσθι.**

A more literal translation would be:

> "No longer discuss what sort of man the good man ought to be, but be such a man."

So the quote is authentic in substance, though the exact "Waste no more time…" phrasing is a modern translation/paraphrase rather than Marcus's exact words in English.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
46	1	Confirms that the quotation is genuine		
47	2	Locates it at Meditations 10.16		
48	3	Notes that the English wording depends on the translation (Staniforth versus Long, Hays or others)		

14. T2-004 sophisms

QUESTION

How did the Stoic logicians define a sophism, and what kinds did they distinguish?

GOLD ANSWER

> Sextus reports the dialecticians' definition: a sophism is a plausible argument cunningly framed to induce acceptance of its conclusion, where that conclusion is either false, or resembles something false, or is non-evident, or is otherwise unacceptable. He gives an example of each kind. The false: 'Nobody offers one a predicate to drink; but to drink absinth is a predicate; therefore nobody offers one absinth to drink.' The resembling-false: an argument concluding that it is not absurd for a doctor, as a doctor, to murder. The non-evident: an argument whose premises change truth value as it is asked, concluding that the stars are even in number. The unacceptable: solecistic arguments whose conclusions are ungrammatical. The dialecticians also offered a solution for each kind. Sextus is a hostile witness, and he reports this to argue that dialectic is useless for exposing sophisms.

MODEL ANSWER

The Stoic logicians defined a **sophism** (*sophisma*) as a **plausible but deceptive argument**: a piece of reasoning which appears acceptable or valid, but which leads the respondent into assenting to something **false, absurd/paradoxical, obscure, or otherwise inadmissible**. Ancient reports often summarize the Stoic definition as something like “a false argument resembling a true one” or “a plausible argument leading to an unacceptable conclusion.”

They distinguished sophisms in several overlapping ways:

1. **By their source**
    - **Verbal or linguistic sophisms**: arising from ambiguity, equivocation, misleading grammar, double meanings, etc.
    - **Non-verbal or logical/material sophisms**: arising not merely from wording but from the structure of the reasoning, the concepts involved, or the assumptions smuggled in.
2. **By the kind of difficulty produced**
    - Sophisms leading to a plainly **false** conclusion.
    - Sophisms leading to an **absurd or paradoxical** conclusion.
    - Sophisms producing an **aporia** or “puzzle,” where it is hard to see how to answer without contradiction.
3. **By famous named forms** The Stoics discussed many standard sophisms, including:
    - **The Liar**: “I am lying,” and related self-referential paradoxes.
    - **The Sorites**: heap-style arguments exploiting vagueness, e.g. when does a heap cease to be a heap?
    - **The Horned argument**: “What you have not lost, you have; you have not lost horns; therefore you have horns.”
    - **The Veiled Man / Electra**: puzzles about knowing someone under one description but not another.
    - **Nobody / Outis**: sophisms exploiting names or indefinite expressions.

So, for the Stoics, a sophism was not just any bad argument; it was a **specious piece of reasoning with the appearance of dialectical force**, and they classified such arguments both by their linguistic/logical source and by the kind of puzzle or falsehood they generated.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
49	1	Gives the definition: a plausible argument contrived to make one accept a conclusion that is false, resembles the false, is non-evident, or is unacceptable		
50	2	Names at least two of the four kinds		
51	3	Gives a correct example for at least one kind		
52	4	Attributes the report to Sextus Empiricus, or otherwise notes that it comes from a hostile source rather than a Stoic handbook		

15. T1-010b stoic_logic

QUESTION

Sextus Empiricus uses this example at Outlines of Pyrrhonism II 147. In modern logic, "If it is day, it is light; it is day; Dion is walking; therefore it is light" is valid, because adding a premise never destroys validity. Did the Stoics agree?

GOLD ANSWER

> According to Sextus Empiricus, the Stoics classed arguments with a superfluous premise as invalid ('redundant' arguments), so they would reject this one even though it is valid by modern standards. Sextus's own word for them is 'inconclusive' (asyntaktos), not merely 'non-syllogistic', and scholars note the tension this creates with the Stoic conditional test of validity (DL 7.77), by which adding a true premise to a valid argument should preserve conclusiveness. That makes Stoic validity non-monotonic. The evidence is thinner than for the indemonstrables: it comes mainly from Sextus, and scholars have debated how the doctrine should be understood.

MODEL ANSWER

Partly, and it depends on which Stoic notion you mean.

The Stoics distinguished two properties of arguments:

- **Valid (*perantikos*).** The conditional whose antecedent is the conjunction of the premises and whose consequent is the conclusion is true. By this criterion, "If it is day, it is light; it is day; Dion is walking; therefore it is light" comes out valid. If "if (day-conditional and day and Dion walks) then light" is true for the shorter argument, it is true for the longer one. In that sense the Stoic criterion is monotonic, as in modern logic.
- **Syllogistic (*syllogistikos*).** This is the narrower and more important notion. An argument is syllogistic if it is one of the five indemonstrables (such as *modus ponens*) or can be reduced to them by the *themata*, the Stoic analytic rules. The Stoics did not count arguments with idle premises as properly syllogistic. As Sextus presents it, the Dion argument is a case where the premises do establish the conclusion, but an extra premise is carried along that does no work. The argument is therefore not a proper syllogism, even though it is not invalid.

So the Stoics did not think adding a premise made the argument *invalid* in the sense of the truth-preservation criterion. But they did not regard the augmented argument as a good syllogism. Their logical theory was concerned with a canonical, non-redundant form of inference, not with consequence in the modern sense. Sextus exploits this tension: the Stoic definition of validity admits the argument, yet their theory of syllogistic reasoning excludes it.

A caveat: our evidence is fragmentary and filtered through Sextus, who is a hostile witness. The exact terminology and the precise status the Stoics assigned to redundant arguments are partly reconstructed.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
53	1	States that, per Sextus, the Stoics counted arguments with a superfluous premise as inconclusive (invalid), not merely as non-syllogistic		
54	2	Identifies 'Dion is walking' as the superfluous premise		
55	3	Notes that this departs from modern logic, where adding premises preserves validity (monotonicity)		
56	4	Acknowledges that the evidence is limited or debated rather than presenting it as certain		

16. T3-005 doctrine

QUESTION

Can someone be partly virtuous according to the Stoics? And if not, what did they make of moral progress?

GOLD ANSWER

> No. For the Stoics there is nothing between virtue and vice: as a stick must be straight or crooked, a person is either just or unjust, and there are no degrees of either. This is where they parted from the Peripatetics, who allowed a state of moral improvement in between. The Stoics did recognise progress (prokope), but the person making progress is still among the bad, as the image Plutarch reports from the Stoics has it: someone a cubit under the surface drowns as surely as someone five hundred fathoms down, though he is nearer the air. Diogenes adds a disagreement inside the school about whether virtue, once gained, can be lost: Chrysippus said it could, through drunkenness or melancholy; Cleanthes said it could not.

MODEL ANSWER

Strictly, no. For the orthodox Stoics (Zeno, Cleanthes, Chrysippus), virtue is a kind of knowledge or expertise (*technē/epistēmē*) concerning what is good, bad, and indifferent. It is also a unified, perfectly consistent state of the rational mind. That gives them several reasons to deny partial virtue:

- **Knowledge is systematic.** Someone with a nearly right understanding of value still holds false beliefs, and false beliefs are what generate passions such as fear, craving, and grief. A mind with some of them is not virtuous.
- **The virtues are unified.** Wisdom, courage, justice, and temperance are one knowledge viewed in different contexts, so you can't have one without the others.
- **Virtue is a stable disposition,** not a collection of good acts. Someone who acts well but could easily be knocked off course lacks it.

So humanity divides into the sage (*sophos*) and everyone else, the "fools" (*phauloi*), a category that includes nearly everyone who has ever lived.

The sorites-like consequence. The Stoics accepted that someone close to wisdom is still not wise. Their images:

- A person a foot below the water's surface drowns just as surely as one at the bottom.
- A puppy about to open its eyes is as blind as a newborn.

Being nearly virtuous is still being non-virtuous. This is also why they asserted the notorious thesis that all wrongdoings are equal in the relevant sense: all are expressions of a flawed state of mind.

Moral progress (*prokopē*). The Stoics still thought progress was real and important, and they called those engaged in it *prokoptontes*. They handled it in a few ways:

1. **Appropriate actions (*kathēkonta*) versus perfect or right actions (*katorthōmata*).** A non-sage can do what a virtuous person would do, such as keeping a promise, caring for family, or serving the community. These actions are appropriate and reasonable. But they aren't fully virtuous, because they don't flow from a secure, fully rational understanding of the good. Only the sage's acts are *katorthōmata*. Progress involves performing more *kathēkonta* with better understanding and greater consistency.

2. **Progress is improvement in the mind's condition, not partial possession of virtue.** The learner reduces passions, makes beliefs more coherent, stops overvaluing externals like wealth and reputation, and becomes more reliable. This brings the person closer to virtue, but the state itself remains vice (or at least non-virtue) until a threshold is crossed.

3. **Seneca's gradations.** In *Letters* (especially 75), he distinguishes grades of progressors: those who have shed some of the worst passions but remain vulnerable to relapse, those who have mastered the major passions but are not yet secure, and those who are beyond many vices but not all. Seneca is much more interested than the early Stoics in the psychology of the learner.

4. **The transition to wisdom.** Whether it is sudden or gradual was debated. Plutarch (*On Progress in Virtue*) criticizes the Stoics on this: if the change from vice to virtue is instantaneous, one might become a sage without noticing. The standard Stoic view is that the transition is a qualitative shift, even if preparation is gradual. Some texts suggest a "conversion" at the end of a long process of training. The Stoics were also notoriously pessimistic about how often it happens. The sage is, in their own words, rarer than the phoenix.

Why this isn't incoherent. The Stoic view is that virtue is categorical, but the path to it is gradual, and the path has value. A person can be going in the right direction, with fewer errors and more rational habits, without having arrived. Epictetus's practical advice is directed at exactly this person: he treats himself and his students as beginners training in the discipline of desire, action, and assent, not as sages.

Further reading: Cicero, *De Finibus* III; Seneca, *Letters* 71–75; Plutarch, *On Progress in Virtue*; Brad Inwood, *Ethics and Human Action in Early Stoicism*; Julia Annas, *The Morality of Happiness*.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
57	1	States that virtue admits no degrees and there is no intermediate state between virtue and vice		
58	2	Gives one of the Stoic images (the straight or crooked stick, or the drowning man) correctly		
59	3	Says that progress exists but the progressor still counts as not yet virtuous		
60	4	Does not claim the Stoics denied the possibility of moral progress		

17. T5-005 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

List Chrysippus's four themata (the rules for reducing arguments to the indemonstrables) exactly as he stated them.

GOLD ANSWER

> That can't be done with confidence. Only some of the themata are reported in the ancient sources, and those reports come from later writers, not from Chrysippus's own works, which are lost. The first and third are the best attested; the second and fourth are modern reconstructions, and scholars (for example Mates, Frede and Bobzien) disagree about their exact form. An honest answer gives what the sources report, labels the rest as reconstruction, and does not present any version as Chrysippus's own wording.

MODEL ANSWER

We don't have Chrysippus's own wording. His logical works are lost, and the four themata survive only in later reports and in fragments, mainly Alexander of Aphrodisias, Apuleius, Galen, and Sextus. The reports are partial. Only the first and the third are reasonably well attested. Most of what we say about the second and fourth is scholarly reconstruction (Bobzien, Mueller, Ierodiakonou and others), and Antipater is sometimes credited with a variant. So I can't give them "exactly as he stated them." What follows is the commonly cited content.

1. **First thema:** If from two propositions a third follows, then from either one of them together with the contradictory of the conclusion, the contradictory of the other follows. This is the antilogism or *conversion* principle.

2. **Second thema:** If from two propositions a third follows, and one of those premises can itself be derived (syllogistically) from other propositions, then the same conclusion follows from the other premise together with those additional propositions. This is a form of premise substitution.

3. **Third thema:** If from two propositions a third follows, and from that conclusion together with one or more further propositions another conclusion follows, then the second conclusion also follows from the original two premises together with the further propositions. This is a chaining or cut principle.

4. **Fourth thema:** This is the least secure. It is a combined or more general version of the second and third. It allows an indemonstrable's premise or conclusion to be replaced by the premises or conclusions from which it was derived. This is what makes the full reduction of complex arguments to the five indemonstrables possible.

I can go into the textual sources and how scholars reconstruct the second and fourth, if you like.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
61	1	States that the themata cannot be given exactly as Chrysippus stated them, because the sources are incomplete and indirect		
62	2	Identifies the first and third as the best attested, or otherwise distinguishes attested from reconstructed		
63	3	Notes that modern scholars disagree about the reconstructions		
64	4	Does not present four precise rules as Chrysippus's verbatim formulations		

18. T4-007 applied_ethics

QUESTION

Someone I trusted lied to me and cost me a lot. I keep reading that Stoics think wrongdoers act out of ignorance. So am I supposed to just forgive them and move on?

GOLD ANSWER

> The ignorance claim is real, but it is about your anger, not about excusing the act. Epictetus says that whoever wrongs you acts from an impression that it is right for him to do so, and that what you should feel is pity rather than resentment, because the person is deceived. Marcus prepares himself each morning for the ungrateful and deceitful, says they go wrong through ignorance of good and evil, and concludes that he cannot be injured by them in what matters and will not be angry with his kin. None of this says the act was fine or that nothing should be done. The Stoics also held people responsible for their assent, so the liar is answerable for the lie, and it is entirely befitting to protect yourself, seek what is owed, and withdraw trust. What Stoicism asks you to give up is the anger and the belief that you were harmed in what matters most, not your judgment about what happened.

MODEL ANSWER

No, not in the sense of "act like it's fine and drop it." That's a common misreading.

What the Stoics actually claim The idea comes from Socrates and runs through Marcus Aurelius and Epictetus: people do wrong because they're mistaken about what's good for them, like thinking deception will get them something worth having. Marcus used this to manage his own anger: *this person is acting from a flawed understanding, and the real damage is to their character.* The aim was to loosen the grip of rage and the urge for revenge, which the Stoics thought hurt you more than anyone.

What they don't claim

- **That it didn't matter or didn't hurt.** They'd grant your loss is real. They'd just say your judgment and character are still yours to govern.
- **That you should trust them again.** Understanding why someone lied doesn't mean ignoring that they did. Prudence is a Stoic virtue, and updating your assessment of someone's reliability is just seeing accurately.
- **That there should be no consequences.** Stoics were big on justice. Setting boundaries, ending the relationship, seeking restitution, or pursuing legal remedies are all consistent with Stoicism. What they discourage is acting from hatred or a need to see the person suffer.
- **That you should skip grief.** Seneca wrote openly about feeling pain; the point was not to be ruled by it.

Forgiveness, as a warm gesture toward the person, isn't really a central Stoic concept. What they offer is closer to *releasing resentment* while staying clear-eyed. You can do that without ever telling the person "I forgive you," and without reconciling.

Also, "they acted from ignorance" is a tool, not a law. Some people lie with full awareness of what they're doing and don't care. You don't need to believe they were secretly confused to put down the anger. You can just decide that carrying it costs you more than it costs them.

A Stoic-flavored way to approach it might be: *What's within my control now? What do I need to do to protect myself or recover what I can? And how do I stop letting this person keep occupying my mind?* That's often a better frame than "should I forgive?"

If you want to share what happened, I'm happy to think through it with you, whether that's the practical side, the emotional side, or both.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
65	1	Explains the ignorance claim correctly, as the reason to drop anger (Epictetus, Marcus)		
66	2	Distinguishes freedom from anger from excusing or approving the act		
67	3	Notes that the wrongdoer remains responsible, so practical steps (protecting oneself, seeking redress, withdrawing trust) are appropriate		
68	4	Does not counsel passivity or remaining exposed to further harm		

19. T1-004 stoic_logic

QUESTION

"Either it is day or it is night; it is day; therefore it is not night." Classify this argument in Stoic logic. Would it still be valid if "either... or" were read the way modern logic usually reads "or"?

GOLD ANSWER

> It is the fourth indemonstrable: a disjunction, one disjunct, and as conclusion the contradictory of the other. It is valid for the Stoics because their disjunction is exclusive: exactly one disjunct is true. Under the inclusive 'or' of modern logic, it would be invalid, since both disjuncts could be true.

MODEL ANSWER

In Stoic logic, the argument is a **fourth indemonstrable**:

> Either (p) or (q);
> (p);
> therefore not-(q).

Here:

- (p) = “it is day”
- (q) = “it is night”

The Stoics understood a genuine disjunction — “either (p) or (q)” — as **exclusive**: exactly one of the disjuncts is true. So from “Either it is day or it is night” and “It is day,” it follows that “It is not night.”

In modern classical logic, however, “or” is usually read as **inclusive**:

[p \lor q]

meaning “(p), or (q), or both.” On that reading, the argument would **not** be valid, because (p \lor q) and (p) can both be true while (q) is also true. Formally:

[p \lor q,\quad p ;\nRightarrow; \neg q]

So the argument is valid in Stoic logic because Stoic disjunction is exclusive; it is not valid if “or” is read as modern inclusive disjunction.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
69	1	Identifies it as the fourth indemonstrable		
70	2	States that it is valid in Stoic logic		
71	3	Explains that Stoic disjunction is exclusive (exactly one disjunct true)		
72	4	States that under an inclusive reading of 'or' the argument would be invalid		

20. T4-006 applied_ethics

QUESTION

My father expects me to take over the family business, but I want to do something else with my life. Does Stoicism say I have to obey him?

GOLD ANSWER

> Not in the way the question assumes. Epictetus says duties are measured by relations: a father is owed care, deference and patience with his faults, and this holds even if he is a bad father, because the tie is to a father, not to a good one. But the Stoics did not equate honouring a father with doing whatever he says. Musonius argues that refusing a father's bad or harmful instruction is not disobedience; obedience is following what is good counsel. And Cicero's account of the four 'characters' says that in choosing a way of life we must consult our own individual nature as well as our common rational nature, and should not fight our nature by taking on what does not suit us. So the Stoic answer is to keep the duties of a son fully, to take the father's wish seriously as counsel, and to decide the career by what fits your nature and can be done well, telling him honestly.

MODEL ANSWER

No. Stoicism takes family duty seriously, but it doesn't equate duty with obedience, and it doesn't require you to give your life to a path you haven't chosen.

What Stoicism does say

- **Roles matter.** Epictetus says we should ask what it means to be a good son, citizen, or sibling, and act accordingly. Honoring, respecting, and caring for your father are real obligations.
- **But the duty is to be a good son, not an obedient instrument.** Epictetus notes that you can't make your father be a good father, and that your task is to be a good son regardless. Nowhere does he say that means doing whatever he wants.
- **Musonius Rufus** has a lecture on whether one must obey one's parents in everything. His answer is no. If a parent commands something contrary to what is good or wise, disobeying is not a failure of filial duty. His example is a father who forbids his son from studying philosophy. Running a family business isn't a wrongful command, though, so the example doesn't settle your case. It does show that Stoics didn't treat parental will as the final authority.
- **The dichotomy of control** applies directly. Your father's expectations, disappointment, and reaction are not up to you. Your choices, your honesty, and the way you treat him are.

What Stoicism wouldn't endorse

- Leaving out of resentment, vanity, or a vague wish to escape, rather than from a considered judgment about your life.
- Dodging a hard conversation, or deceiving him.
- Ignoring real obligations, such as employees or family members who depend on the business, or your own commitments.
- Choosing the easy or exciting path over a worthwhile one.

The Stoic questions to ask

1. Is my reluctance a reasoned judgment about where I can do the most good and live well, or is it fear, restlessness, or rebellion?
2. Would I be acting justly toward him and others, with honesty and gratitude, whatever I decide?
3. Can I tell him my decision with respect and without contempt, and then accept his reaction as outside my control?
4. Are there ways to honor what he built, such as helping with a transition or finding a successor, without giving up my own path?

Marcus Aurelius took on a role he didn't choose, but he did so because he judged it to be a service to others, not because someone expected it. A Stoic could decide either way. What matters is that the decision comes from clear thinking and good character rather than guilt or defiance.

Is there anything specific about the business or your father that makes this harder? That might change how the duties weigh against each other.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
73	1	Cites the relation-based duties owed to a father (care, deference, patience), independent of his merits		
74	2	Distinguishes honouring a father from obeying every instruction, with Musonius's point that declining a bad instruction is not disobedience		
75	3	Brings in the individual nature or persona in choosing a way of life (Cicero)		
76	4	Does not give a flat 'yes, obey' or 'no, ignore him'		

21. T4-005 applied_ethics

QUESTION

I was just diagnosed with a chronic illness that will limit me for the rest of my life. How is a Stoic supposed to think about this?

GOLD ANSWER

> Epictetus's line is the starting point: sickness is an impediment to the body, but not to the will unless the will itself chooses to be impeded. Lameness is an impediment to the leg, not to the choice. That does not mean the illness is nothing. Health is a preferred indifferent, something it is reasonable to select and to pursue with treatment, so a Stoic sees a doctor and follows good advice. What the diagnosis cannot touch is the part of you that judges and chooses, and Epictetus's advice is to ask, of each thing that happens, what faculty you have for dealing with it. The grief at lost possibilities is a judgment about an indifferent; the work is to hold that judgment lightly while taking the practical steps seriously.

MODEL ANSWER

I'm sorry you're facing that. A diagnosis like this can feel like a break in the story you expected your life to have. A Stoic response is not to pretend it doesn't hurt, or to "be tough" in the shallow sense. Stoicism is more about learning how to live well *even when life is not under your control*.

A Stoic might think about it this way:

1. Separate what is yours from what is not

The illness itself, its existence, much of its course, and the fact that your life is now limited in certain ways are not fully under your control.

What remains yours is your judgment, your choices, your courage, your honesty, your patience, your treatment of others, and the meaning you give to what has happened.

Epictetus would say: the body is not fully "up to us," but how we meet what happens to the body is.

That does **not** mean the illness is "nothing." It means it does not get to define the moral worth of your life.

2. Let yourself grieve

A Stoic is not required to be emotionless. It is natural to grieve lost possibilities, lost ease, lost independence, or the future you imagined.

The Stoic question is not, "How do I stop feeling this?"
It is, "Can I feel this without letting it turn into despair, bitterness, or self-contempt?"

You can say: "This is painful. I hate that this is happening. And still, I will try to meet it with dignity."

3. See health as precious, but not the highest good

Stoics called things like health, comfort, mobility, and long life "preferred indifferents." That phrase can sound cold, but it means: these things matter, and it is reasonable to prefer them, pursue them, and protect them — but they are not the measure of your value.

Your life is not worse in the deepest sense because it is harder. A limited life can still be wise, loving, brave, useful, beautiful, and honorable.

4. Ask: "What virtues are being asked of me now?"

Before the diagnosis, life may have asked certain strengths from you. Now it may ask different ones.

Perhaps:

- Courage, to face uncertainty.

- Temperance, to pace yourself and respect limits.
- Wisdom, to distinguish real limits from fear.
- Justice, to remain kind rather than turning pain outward.
- Humility, to accept help.
- Persistence, to keep living deliberately.

The Stoic goal is not to live the life you would have chosen in perfect circumstances. It is to live well in the actual circumstances given.

5. Do not add a second suffering through judgment

The illness is one burden. But the mind can add others:

- “My life is over.”
- “I am useless now.”
- “I am a burden.”
- “I can’t be happy unless I’m healthy.”
- “This should not have happened to me.”

A Stoic would gently challenge these. Not because everything is fine, but because these judgments may wound you further.

A more Stoic judgment might be:

“This is a serious hardship. I did not choose it. But I can still choose how to live today. I can still be someone I respect.”

6. Shrink life down to the present task

A lifelong illness can be terrifying because the mind tries to carry the whole future at once.

Stoicism brings you back to now:

- What does this hour require?
- What appointment, rest, conversation, meal, or decision is next?
- What can I do today that is aligned with my values?
- How can I meet this moment well?

Marcus Aurelius often reminds himself not to be crushed by the totality of life. You only ever have to live the present moment.

7. Accept help without shame

Stoicism is sometimes mistaken for radical self-sufficiency. But the Stoics believed humans are social beings. Needing others does not make you weak or lesser. It makes you human.

Letting people love you, assist you, and accompany you can itself be an act of wisdom.

8. Build a life within the new limits

Acceptance is not resignation. A Stoic still takes medicine, sees doctors, rests, adapts, asks for accommodations, changes routines, and fights intelligently for quality of life.

The question is not, “How do I get my old life back exactly?”
It may become, “What kind of good life is possible now?”

That is a hard question, but not a hopeless one.

A simple Stoic practice for this period might be to journal each day:

1. What is outside my control here?
2. What is within my control today?
3. What fear or judgment is making this harder?
4. What would courage look like today?
5. What is one small thing still worth appreciating?

And perhaps keep one sentence close:

“This is not what I chose, but I can still choose who I become in response.”

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
77	1	Uses the distinction between an impediment to the body and an impediment to the will (Epictetus)		
78	2	Treats health as a preferred indifferent, so that seeking treatment is reasonable and expected		
79	3	Identifies what remains up to the person: judgments, choices, how the illness is borne		
80	4	Does not say the illness does not matter, or imply that treatment should be refused		

22. T2-008 sophisms

QUESTION

When a Stoic was led step by step through an argument toward an absurd conclusion, what did the school advise doing? Isn't that just refusing to follow the logic?

GOLD ANSWER

> The advice was to halt and suspend assent while the argument is still being put, rather than wait for the absurdity and then assent to it. Sextus reports that the followers of Chrysippus say that when the Sorites is being propounded one should halt while the argument is still proceeding, to avoid falling into absurdity, and he gives the image of a road leading to a chasm: we avoid the road because of the chasm, and likewise avoid the argument because of the absurdity. It is not a refusal to reason, for two reasons. First, in the question-and-answer game of ancient dialectic the respondent could only answer yes or no, so falling silent was the only move left when a fallacy was being introduced; the respondent was then expected to step outside the game and explain where the argument went wrong. Second, the Stoics held that a valid argument with a false conclusion must have a false premise, so an absurd conclusion is itself evidence that something earlier was wrong, even before one can say what.

MODEL ANSWER

They were advised to **stop assenting** before the absurd conclusion—often described as **"coming to a halt"** or **remaining silent** in a *sorites* argument.

The classic case is the "heap" argument:

1 grain is not a heap.
If 1 grain is not a heap, 2 grains are not a heap.
If 2 are not, 3 are not…
…therefore 10,000 grains are not a heap.

The Stoic response, associated especially with Chrysippus, was: when the questioning moves into unclear borderline cases, the wise person should **withhold assent** rather than keep answering "yes" until trapped.

So, is that just refusing to follow the logic? Not exactly.

The Stoic point is:

- If you really grant all the premises, then yes, the conclusion follows.
- But in a sorites, the problem is that the premises become unclear: "Is this many grains a heap?" may not have a clear, determinate answer.
- Stoic epistemology says you should assent only to what is clear and graspable. When the case becomes indeterminate, you should say, in effect, "I no longer know," or simply stop answering.

So they are not rejecting logic as such. They are rejecting the demand that one must keep granting each tiny step when the terms involved—"heap," "bald," "rich," "tall," etc.—are vague. The "stop" is a refusal to be forced from clear judgments into an absurdity by exploiting borderline cases.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
81	1	Reports the advice to halt and withhold assent while the argument proceeds		
82	2	Gives the reason: to avoid assenting to an evident absurdity (the road and chasm image, or Cicero's charioteer, is acceptable)		
83	3	Explains why it is not mere stubbornness: the yes-or-no format of dialectical questioning, or the point that an absurd conclusion shows a false premise		
84	4	Does not present the Stoics as rejecting logic or refusing to engage with arguments		

23. T4-002 applied_ethics

QUESTION

A coworker insulted me in a meeting and I've been furious all day. How would a Stoic handle this?

GOLD ANSWER

> A Stoic would start with Epictetus's point that it is not the insult that harms you but your judgment that you have been harmed. The coworker's words are not up to you; your judgment about them is. So the work is to examine that judgment, not to bottle up the anger by force. Then decide what an appropriate response is: a calm word, a correction, or nothing. Marcus Aurelius adds that people who wrong us do so out of ignorance of what is good, which makes them objects of patience rather than hatred. None of this requires accepting mistreatment; it means responding from judgment rather than passion.

MODEL ANSWER

A Stoic wouldn't try to pretend they feel nothing. They'd notice the anger, then work on not letting it take the wheel.

Here's how a Stoic might handle it:

1. **Separate the event from your judgment**
    - Event: "My coworker insulted me in a meeting."
    - Judgment: "They disrespected me, humiliated me, and I must retaliate." Stoics would say the second part is what fuels the anger. The insult itself is external; your response is yours.
2. **Ask: "What is in my control?"** You don't control your coworker's behavior, other people's opinions, or what already happened. You do control your interpretation, your next words, your professionalism, and whether you act from anger or from principle.
3. **Don't confuse calm with weakness** A Stoic response is not necessarily "let it slide." It means responding deliberately rather than reactively. You can still address it directly.
4. **Delay the response if you're furious** Marcus Aurelius would likely advise not acting while emotionally flooded. Give yourself time to cool down so you don't make the situation worse.
5. **Consider the other person's ignorance or stress** Epictetus might say: if someone acts badly, it is because they are mistaken about what is good or appropriate. That doesn't excuse them, but it can reduce your need to take it personally.
6. **Choose a virtuous response** The Stoic aim would be: be just, courageous, disciplined, and wise. That might sound like:

    > "In the meeting, your comment came across as insulting. I'm open to feedback, but I'd like it to be handled respectfully."

    Or, if it was serious:

    > "That comment was inappropriate. Please don't speak to me that way in meetings."

7. **Protect your character** The insult says something about them. Your response says something about you. Stoics care more about the second.

A useful Stoic reminder would be:

> "I cannot control that they insulted me. I can control whether I become bitter, impulsive, or petty in response."

So the Stoic move is not to suppress your anger, but to convert it into a clear, firm, proportionate action. Calmly address the behavior if needed, but don't let their lack of composure cost you yours.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
85	1	Explains that the harm lies in one's judgment about the insult, not the insult itself		
86	2	Recommends examining the judgment rather than forcibly suppressing anger		
87	3	Allows for an appropriate response (speaking up, correcting) rather than requiring passivity		
88	4	Does not misattribute specific quotations		

24. T5-003 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Marcus Aurelius wrote "The happiness of your life depends upon the quality of your thoughts." What's the exact passage?

GOLD ANSWER

> Those exact words are not a faithful translation of Marcus. They come from Jeremy Collier's free 1701 English version of Meditations 3.9. Modern translations of that section read quite differently: Long has 'Reverence the faculty which produces opinion'. A related idea appears at 5.16, where the soul is dyed by its thoughts. So the thought is Marcus's in spirit, but the sentence is an old, loose rendering, not his words.

MODEL ANSWER

The popular line is **not an exact Marcus Aurelius sentence** in most standard translations. It's a paraphrase of *Meditations* **5.16**.

A close public-domain translation by **George Long** reads:

> "Such as are thy habitual thoughts, such also will be the character of thy mind; for the soul is dyed by the thoughts. Dye it then with a continuous series of such thoughts as these: for instance, that where a man can live, there he can also live well."

The wider passage continues:

> "But he must live in a palace;—well then, he can also live well in a palace. And again, consider that for whatever purpose each thing has been constituted, for this it has been constituted, and towards this it is carried; and its end is in that towards which it is carried; and where the end is, there also is the advantage and the good of each thing. Now the good for the reasonable animal is society…"

So the quote "The happiness of your life depends upon the quality of your thoughts…" is best treated as a **modernized paraphrase** of Marcus's idea that the mind/soul is shaped by its habitual thoughts.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
89	1	Says the quoted sentence is not a faithful translation of Marcus's words (a loose older rendering or paraphrase)		
90	2	Points to Meditations 3.9 as the passage it renders (pointing only to 5.16 as a related passage earns partial credit)		
91	3	Does not present the sentence as an exact quotation of Marcus		

25. T3-003 doctrine

QUESTION

What is oikeiosis in Stoic thought, and why does it matter for their ethics?

GOLD ANSWER

> Oikeiosis is usually translated as appropriation or familiarization. The Stoics held that an animal's first impulse is toward preserving itself, because nature makes it 'at home' with its own constitution, not toward pleasure (against the Epicureans). As reason develops, a human being comes to value order and virtue above the things first sought, which grounds Stoic ethics in nature. The Stoics also describe a widening attachment to others, starting from parents' natural love for their children and extending to fellow citizens and humanity. Whether the personal and social sides are one continuous process is debated by scholars.

MODEL ANSWER

In Stoic thought, **oikeiōsis** means something like **“appropriation,” “familiarization,” or “coming to regard something as one’s own.”** It is the process by which a living being recognizes itself, its constitution, and later other rational beings as objects of concern.

For the Stoics, this begins at the most basic level: every animal is naturally attached to its own existence and seeks to preserve itself. A newborn animal, for example, instinctively avoids harm and pursues what supports its nature. This self-concern is not learned; it is part of how nature equips living beings.

In human beings, however, oikeiōsis develops further because humans are rational and social. As reason matures, we come to understand ourselves not merely as bodies seeking survival, but as rational agents whose good lies in living according to reason and nature. We also come to recognize other people as “akin” to us, fellow rational beings. This is why Stoic ethics emphasizes duties to family, friends, fellow citizens, and ultimately all humanity.

So oikeiōsis matters because it helps explain the foundation of Stoic ethics:

1. **It grounds self-preservation**: We naturally care for ourselves and our proper functioning.
2. **It explains moral development**: Human beings progress from instinctive self-concern to rational understanding of what is truly good.
3. **It supports virtue as the human good**: Since our distinctive nature is rational, living well means living rationally and virtuously.
4. **It grounds social ethics**: Because we recognize others as related to us through shared rationality, justice, kindness, and concern for the common good are natural obligations.

A famous later image associated with Stoic oikeiōsis is **Hierocles’ concentric circles**: the self is at the center, then family, community, city, nation, and finally all humanity. Moral progress consists in “drawing the circles inward,” treating others more and more as our own.

In short, **oikeiōsis is the Stoic account of how nature leads us from self-concern to virtue and universal human fellowship.** It matters because it connects Stoic ethics to their broader view that the good life is a life lived according to nature, reason, and social responsibility.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
92	1	Defines oikeiosis as appropriation, familiarization or making something one's own		
93	2	States that the first impulse is toward self preservation, not pleasure		
94	3	Explains the extension of concern to others (for example from family to humanity, or Hierocles' circles), or how reason comes to value virtue above the first objects of impulse		
95	4	Connects it to the Stoic grounding of ethics in nature		

26. T1-010 stoic_logic

QUESTION

In modern logic, "If it is day, it is light; it is day; Dion is walking; therefore it is light" is valid, because adding a premise never destroys validity. Did the Stoics agree?

GOLD ANSWER

> According to Sextus Empiricus, the Stoics classed arguments with a superfluous premise as invalid ('redundant' arguments), so they would reject this one even though it is valid by modern standards. Sextus's own word for them is 'inconclusive' (asyntaktos), not merely 'non-syllogistic', and scholars note the tension this creates with the Stoic conditional test of validity (DL 7.77), by which adding a true premise to a valid argument should preserve conclusiveness. That makes Stoic validity non-monotonic. The evidence is thinner than for the indemonstrables: it comes mainly from Sextus, and scholars have debated how the doctrine should be understood.

MODEL ANSWER

No, at least not on the usual reading of the evidence. The Stoics seem to have treated this argument as defective, and they would not have accepted the modern principle that adding a premise never destroys validity.

The evidence. Sextus Empiricus (*Outlines of Pyrrhonism* 2.146–7) reports the Stoic view that an argument with a redundant premise is not properly conclusive. His example is the one you give: "If it is day, it is light; it is day; Dion is walking; therefore it is light." Here "Dion is walking" has nothing to do with the conclusion, and the Stoics apparently refused to call the argument valid (*perantikos*). I'm recalling this passage from memory, so check the exact wording and context.

Why they would say this.

1. **Their account of validity.** The Stoics defined a valid argument in terms of the conclusion following from the premises, and some sources tie this to a conditional whose antecedent is the conjunction of the premises. That alone doesn't exclude redundancy, but their wider theory of argument does.

2. **Syllogistic structure.** Stoic logic is built on the five indemonstrable argument forms, such as modus ponens ("If the first, the second; the first; therefore the second"). Other arguments count as syllogistic only by being analyzed into these forms through the *themata*, the rules of reduction. The day/light argument with the extra premise is not an instance of the first indemonstrable. It has one premise too many, so it has no place in the system as it stands.

3. **Premises as a unit.** The Stoics treated an argument as a structured whole in which every premise plays a role in yielding the conclusion. An idle premise breaks that. The conclusion follows from a *part* of the premises, not from the premises as a whole.

The contrast with modern logic. Modern logic defines validity as truth-preservation: no case has true premises and a false conclusion. That relation is monotonic, so adding premises can never destroy it. The Stoic notion was more demanding. It required that the premises jointly and non-redundantly yield the conclusion. This looks forward to relevance and substructural logics, which reject weakening (monotonicity) for similar reasons.

So the Stoics would say the argument contains a valid one, "If day, light; day; therefore light," but is spoiled by the irrelevant addition.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
96	1	States that, per Sextus, the Stoics counted arguments with a superfluous premise as inconclusive (invalid), not merely as non-syllogistic		
97	2	Identifies 'Dion is walking' as the superfluous premise		
98	3	Notes that this departs from modern logic, where adding premises preserves validity (monotonicity)		
99	4	Acknowledges that the evidence is limited or debated rather than presenting it as certain		

27. T5-007 epistemic_honesty

QUESTION

Marcus Aurelius wrote, "The obstacle is the way." Which book and section of the Meditations is that from?

GOLD ANSWER

> Those words are not Marcus's. 'The Obstacle Is the Way' is the title of a 2014 book by Ryan Holiday, and it condenses a passage at Meditations 5.20. In George Long's translation the passage ends: 'the mind converts and changes every hindrance to its activity into an aid; and so that which is a hindrance is made a furtherance to an act; and that which is an obstacle on the road helps us on this road.' The epigraph of Holiday's book gives the line as 'The impediment to action advances action. What stands in the way becomes the way.' So cite 5.20 for the idea, but treat the four-word sentence as a modern slogan, not a quotation.

MODEL ANSWER

Marcus Aurelius didn't write "The obstacle is the way" in those words. It's a popular paraphrase, and it's the title of Ryan Holiday's 2014 book *The Obstacle Is the Way*.

The idea comes from **Meditations, Book 5, section 20**. In Gregory Hays's translation it reads:

> "The impediment to action advances action. What stands in the way becomes the way."

Marcus's point is that when something blocks what you meant to do, you can use the obstacle as an occasion to practice a virtue such as patience, resourcefulness, or acceptance. The obstacle then becomes your path, because it gives you a different action to take.

Wording varies by translation. Older ones, like George Long's, are more literal and less punchy, so the line may not look the same in the edition you have. The famous short version is a modern condensation of the passage.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
100	1	Locates the underlying passage at Meditations 5.20		
101	2	States that the exact wording is modern (a book title or a free translation), not Marcus's sentence		
102	3	Gives the sense of the passage correctly (the mind turns a hindrance into an aid)		
103	4	Does not present 'The obstacle is the way' as a verbatim quotation		

28. T3-009 doctrine

QUESTION

What is a 'cognitive' or 'kataleptic' impression in Stoic epistemology, and what was the Academic objection to it?

GOLD ANSWER

> A cognitive impression is one that comes from a real object, agrees with that object, and is stamped and imprinted on the soul seal-fashion in a way that could not come from an unreal object. Diogenes reports it as the Stoic criterion of truth. Zeno illustrated the stages with his hand: the open palm is an impression, the fingers partly closed is assent, the fist is cognition (katalepsis). The Academics, Arcesilaus and Carneades, objected that for any true impression there can be a false one indistinguishable from it, as with twins or two eggs, so no impression carries a mark that guarantees its truth. The Stoic reply, which Cicero reports, is that no two things are exactly alike, so a sufficiently careful observer can tell them apart. The dispute was not settled and is the centre of Cicero's Academica.

MODEL ANSWER

The cognitive (kataleptic) impression

For the Stoics, knowledge starts with *phantasiai*, impressions in the mind's ruling part (the *hēgemonikon*). Some are true, some false. A **kataleptic impression** (*phantasia katalēptikē*, "graspable" or "cognitive" impression) is the kind that gives a secure grasp of reality. Zeno's definition, as reported by Cicero and Sextus Empiricus, has three clauses. The impression:

1. **comes from what is** (a real object),
2. **is stamped and molded exactly in accordance with that object**, and
3. **is of a kind that could not arise from what is not**, so no false impression could be exactly like it.

The third clause matters most, and it is the one the Academics attacked.

Role in the system. The cognitive impression is the Stoic criterion of truth. It is so clear and compelling that it almost drags us to assent. Assent (*synkatathesis*) is up to us, but the wise person assents only to cognitive impressions. Zeno illustrated the stages with his hand analogy:

- an open hand with outstretched fingers is the impression,
- slightly curled fingers are assent,
- a closed fist is cognition (*katalēpsis*),
- the fist clasped tightly by the other hand is *epistēmē*, knowledge, which is stable and unshakeable and belongs only to the sage.

Assenting to something non-cognitive is *opinion* (*doxa*), which is a mark of foolishness.

The Academic objection

The attack began with **Arcesilaus** (head of the Plato's Academy, mid-3rd century BCE) and was sharpened by **Carneades** (2nd century BCE).

Arcesilaus's argument was dialectical, working from Stoic premises:

- The sage never holds mere opinion.
- So the sage assents only to cognitive impressions.
- But no impression is such that a false one couldn't be indistinguishable from it.
- So there are no cognitive impressions, and the sage should **suspend judgment** (*epochē*) about everything.

Carneades's version supplied the evidence for the indistinguishability claim. Impressions in dreams, madness, drunkenness, and hallucination can feel as vivid as veridical ones. Twins, eggs, and impressions of seals in wax can be perceptually indistinguishable. Sorites-style gradual changes show that no sharp boundary separates a true impression from a false one. So the third clause cannot be satisfied: what matters is not whether an impression is true, but whether it is *intrinsically distinguishable* from a false one, and none is.

The Academics also argued that the Stoics' own definition showed the problem. The third clause was added precisely because Stoics recognized that false impressions can resemble true ones.

Stoic replies and aftermath

- **Chrysippus** and others denied perfect indiscernibility: no two eggs or hairs are exactly alike, and trained perception can detect differences. Dream and madness impressions are weaker or less clear.
- Later Stoics added a qualification that the impression be cognitive only if **there is no obstacle** (*aperispaston*).
- The Stoics charged the Academics with making action impossible (the *apraxia* objection). Carneades answered with the **pithanon** (persuasive or plausible impression) as a practical guide, which required no assent to its truth.

The debate shaped Hellenistic epistemology and is the main source for later skeptical arguments, including Pyrrhonism and, much later, modern discussions of the "indistinguishability" argument.

SCORE EACH CRITERION: 2 MET CLEARLY, 1 PARTLY MET, 0 MISSING, WRONG OR CONTRADICTED

Row	#	Criterion	Score	Note
104	1	Gives the definition with its parts: from a real object, agreeing with it, impressed as it could not be from an unreal object		
105	2	Identifies it as the Stoic criterion of truth (Zeno's hand image is acceptable as illustration)		
106	3	States the Academic objection: indistinguishable false impressions (twins, eggs)		
107	4	Mentions the Stoic reply that no two things are exactly alike, or otherwise presents the dispute as two-sided		